

AI Tool Stack & Guide for Canadian Contractors & SMBs

The 10 AI tools saving Canadian business owners 20+ hours per week

Writing & Content

Claude (Anthropic) — Best for: long-form writing, analysis, coding

- claude.ai — Free tier available, Pro at \$20/month CAD
- Best use: proposals, emails, contracts, reports

ChatGPT (OpenAI) — Best for: quick answers, brainstorming

- chat.openai.com — Free tier, Plus at \$20/month
- Best use: first drafts, customer emails, social posts

Design & Visual

Canva AI — Best for: social media, presentations, flyers

- canva.com — Free tier, Pro at \$17/month CAD
- Best use: Instagram posts, business cards, proposals

Adobe Firefly — Best for: professional image generation

- firefly.adobe.com — Included with Creative Cloud
- Best use: product mockups, background removal, brand assets

Productivity & Automation

Notion AI — Best for: project management + AI writing

- notion.so — Free tier, Plus at \$10/month
- Best use: SOPs, client onboarding docs, project tracking

Zapier — Best for: connecting apps without coding

- zapier.com — Free tier (100 tasks/mo), Starter at \$19/month
- Best use: auto-route leads, sync CRM, email triggers

Make (formerly Integromat) — More powerful than Zapier

- make.com — Free tier, Core at \$9/month
- Best use: complex multi-step automations

Finance & Accounting

Wave — Best for: free invoicing and accounting

- waveapps.com — Free (pay per transaction for payments)
- Best use: invoicing, expense tracking, basic reports

QuickBooks Online — Best for: growing businesses

- quickbooks.intuit.com — Simple Start at \$20/month CAD
- Best use: HST filing, payroll, bank reconciliation

Dext (formerly Receipt Bank) — Best for: receipt capture

- dext.com — From \$20/month, integrates with QB and Wave

Customer & Sales

HubSpot CRM — Best for: managing leads and clients

- hubspot.com — Free CRM, Marketing starts at \$20/month
- Best use: pipeline tracking, email sequences, deal management

ManyChat — Best for: Instagram and Facebook DM automation

- manychat.com — Free tier, Pro at \$15/month
- Best use: auto-reply to comments, lead capture from social

Time-Saving Tips

- Start with free tiers — most tools above have generous free plans
- Pick one tool per category — don't stack duplicates
- Automate your biggest time wasters first (invoicing, follow-ups)
- Use Claude to write your SOPs, then store them in Notion
- Connect your tools with Zapier — one setup saves hours every week